

Android to help create roads

The Bihar govt recently announced that it would use Android phones to ensure that construction of roads continues in a streamlined manner

**Optimus Black**

Mid-Jan LG released the new phone which features NOVA display technology for visibility in bright sunlight, and a slim 9.2mm profile

Android Expeditions

Agent 001 goes on an expedition to uncover the best Android phones in the market.

Agent 001

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The usual suspects at the Digit Office seemed to be a little depressed off late, particularly Sambhav, Nimish and Sid. "Why", you ask? Wouldn't you be too, if Rossi and Rudresh had been strutting around with their Android based Nexus One and Droid phones the whole of last month? Thanks to these rather envious tendencies geeks are susceptible to, everyone seems to have caught Android

Fever. Sambhav and Sid have been Symbian guys for a long time. They looked bleakly at their E63 and N82 and dragged me into a "lets all buy Android Phones" expedition.

Being my methodical self, I asked them what their expectations and price ranges were. Nimish wanted to look at mid-range offer-

ings (between 10k to 15k) while Sambhav was keen on getting a cheap model if the phones on offer were not too horrible. Sid on the other hand wanted something jazzy to match up to his old N82 in terms of specs. He is also more likely to do keedass with his phone such as rooting and using other mods and hence wanted something highspeced - at least a 1GHz processor to make it as future proof as possible. Nimish wanted to try his hand at blackberry-style Qwerty's from the Android world for a long time, and was wondering if any such models exist out there.

I started off with the most confusing and densely populated category - the midrange. What does the market landscape



Samsung Galaxy 3

look like when it comes to Android phones from 10 to 15k? You have a couple of contenders worth considering - LG Optimus

One P500, Samsung Galaxy 3, HTC Wildfire,

Motorola QUENCH XT5, Motorola Charm, and the Samsung Galaxy 551. The first four go head on against one other since they belong to the same form factor (full touch) and are very closely spec-ed. The Wildfire has a screen that leaves a lot to be desired, and though the Motorola Quench XT5 is fast and well built both phones come at a slightly over the top price of about ₹13,500 thanks to their 5MP camera instead of 3.15MP of the others. The Galaxy 3 is a strong contender and the least expensive of the mid-rangers (mop around ₹11.6k). But of these the LG Optimus One emerges as the phone to recommend. It is the only one that comes with Android 2.2 (Froyo) out of the box. The other two phones in this price range were the Galaxy 551 and the Motorola Charm and are somewhat unique. The Galaxy 551 features a slideout Qwerty keypad and

is available for an affordable ₹12,599 on websites such as www.flipkart.com. However the guys held off jumping at this one until it came to the test center for a full review. I got a chance to play with the next phone in this category, the Motorola Charm at a retail chain that priced it at ₹14,000. It is a blackberry-style Qwerty phone that runs on Android 2.1. The Trackpad at the back made for an interesting few

minutes of fascinated fiddling around, but that's about it. Initially, figured Nimish being the serious kind will very easily take to it, but the squarish looks, pale screen, and an OS that seemed forcefit to the formfactor, made me not want to recommend this one.



HTC Desire

For

Sambhav, who was looking at budget options, we considered some models like the Micromax A6 which is available at a market price of around ₹7000

and Samsung Galaxy 5. The Micromax A6 has a resistive screen and Samsung Galaxy 5 (MOP ₹8,900) seems to not be too bad, but I still urged Sambhav to up his budget and go for the safe bet - LG Optimus One.

Sid's requirement was a little higher than the 600 MHz performers we'd seen so far. In the 1GHz category the sky is the limit. You have the Milestone a.k.a Droid selling at around 23.5k or the superlative Samsung Galaxy S at around 27K, if you are willing to shell out that much. But often a price/performance mix is what we're looking for. In that case the recent drop in price of the HTC Desire made it the perfect choice at around 23K. It's got 1GHz Snapdragon, SLCD screen, 5MP

camera with Flash, and is easily upgradable to Froyo. What more could you want? [Psst



LG Optimus One



Samsung Galaxy 551

- We were able to spot it on Flipkart.com for a cool ₹22,699]. All in all this was a fun expedition and a true testament to the rise in popularity of Android Phones in India. 



Motorola Charm